

Laptop Accessories

External mice: It's quite tiresome to work long hours on a laptop, especially if it involves a lot of cursor activity. It is advisable to keep an external USB mouse for such sessions. Many vendors have introduced optical mice for laptops. These are small and fit into your carry case with ease. They are slightly uncomfortable, but still better than the touchpad.

Carry cases: Laptops come with reasonably good looking and sturdy carry cases. These usually have a pocket to accommodate the power adapter. However, if you are a frequent flier and carry other accessories along, look out for specially made laptop bags. Elegant leather bags that have special pockets to keep the power adapter, external optical drives, etc., are more durable than the resin bags provided by the manufacturer. Hard-cased laptop bags protect the laptop from excessive wear and tear.

External laptop coolers: The use of desktop components in entry-level laptops reduces costs. However, these components also dissipate a large amount of heat. Strangely, hardly any of the laptops have ventilation systems efficient enough to deal with this problem.

Companies providing cooling solution for desktops saw this opportunity and developed an external cooling solution for laptops that helps to reduce the heat dissipation. Antec's laptop cooling solution has a plastic base with a brushed perforated aluminum surface that makes contact with your laptop. Two high-rpm fans placed between the plastic base and the aluminum surface draw the heat away from the laptop. Moreover, the cooler is USB-powered and offers a USB port, so that you still have a USB port on the laptop.

External lights: IBM integrates small LEDs into the LCD screen so that you can see the keys clearly when working in the dark. For other laptops, use USB-powered light sources that you can clip to the top of the screen.

Standby batteries: Usually, laptop batteries last for about 5 hours. Hence, it makes sense to carry a charged standby battery along while travelling.

We recommend that you purchase these batteries from the laptop manufacturer rather than from a third-party vendor at a lower rate.

Other accessories: A Kensington lock is a wire lock that can be used to secure the laptop to a desk. Protect your LCD screen using a screen protector. These are thin plastic sheets

that can be stuck to the LCD to prevent it from getting scratched.

Use special lint-free fabrics to clean the LCD screen.



A Kensington lock

Conclusion

The thin and light category saw the largest concentration of products with six laptops, ranging from the modest ACi to the renowned IBM. Similarly, the hardware used also varied widely with the ACi laptop packed to the hilt with the latest and best processor available, while the others relied upon a reasonably fast 1.4 GHz processor.

In the performance aspect, no laptop could come close to the ACi Centrino as far as business applications are concerned. However, the ACi laptop could not repeat the same performance in the rest of the tests. This set the stage for the IBM T40. This participant gave a balanced performance across the entire battery of tests. The Wipro Little Genius and Acer TravelMate 290 made a valiant effort to beat the IBM, but fell short of a few points—0.2 and 0.9, respectively. The contenders from Zenith, BPL and ACi formed a triad that were on par with each other in most of the tests.

Performance apart, no other laptop could match the IBM T40 in terms of usability, features and package bundling. These were the factors that let this contender from IBM sprint ahead of its competitors, and rule this category.

Zenith does not bundle an OS along with its laptop. This certainly helps both Zenith and the consumer, since they can pay for the OS of their choice. The Zenith ONE-UP Notebook (WiFi 4X) priced at Rs 70,000, offers the best bargain deal, thus scoring very high on our value for money scale. As for the Wipro and Acer laptops, they lost to a better product, but not ashamedly so, because they are mighty good for the price they demand.

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